# INCIDENT CLASSIFICATION TABLE

Ghana Maritime Defense Command (GMDC) | Incident Response & Security Operations

## Purpose

provide a consistent method for assigning Low, Medium, High, or Critical severity to suspected or confirmed cybersecurity incidents. This is a proposed internal classification scheme for the GMDC scenario; it is not a claim that an incident has occurred or that Wazuh has been deployed.

## Incident Severity Classification

| Severity | Classification criteria | GMDC-related examples | Initial response and escalation |
|---|---|---|---|
| CRITICAL | Confirmed or strongly indicated compromise of a mission-critical system; active ransomware or destructive malware; confirmed sensitive-data exfiltration; privileged account takeover with broad access; active compromise affecting command-and-control, maritime surveillance, or safety-related operations. | A backdoor on a server is being used to obtain root-level access; ransomware encrypts command-support files; confirmed theft of restricted maritime operational data; compromise disrupts a critical surveillance or communications service. | Immediately notify the Incident Lead/Security Owner and senior management. Activate the incident-response team. Begin urgent containment coordinated with the operational owner. Preserve evidence where safe; maintain an incident log and regular updates. |
| HIGH | Credible evidence of unauthorized access to an important server or | Evidence of exploitation against a publicly reachable web service; | Escalate promptly to the Incident Lead and relevant system/data owner. |

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| | network; exploitation of a serious exposed service; malware on a server or administrator endpoint; likely disclosure of confidential information; significant service degradation without confirmed mission-critical outage. | unauthorized access to a database containing sensitive records; suspicious privileged login; confirmed compromise of a non-mission-critical server; a serious vulnerability is actively being exploited. | Assign responders, restrict affected access or services as appropriate, preserve logs, and provide updates at agreed milestones. |
| MEDIUM | A suspicious event requiring investigation, limited unauthorized access, malware or policy violation on a non-critical endpoint, repeated failed logins, or a contained issue with no current evidence of sensitive-data loss or major operational disruption. | Repeated failed login attempts against a user account; suspicious scanning of a lab web server without evidence of successful exploitation; malware detected on an isolated test workstation; an exposed directory reveals non-sensitive test files. | Record and investigate through the security/IT team. Apply proportionate containment if needed. Notify the affected system owner and raise severity if evidence shows successful access, sensitive data exposure, or broader impact. |
| LOW | An isolated, low-impact event with no evidence of successful compromise, sensitive-data exposure, or material service disruption; a benign alert confirmed | A single blocked connection from an unknown source; an isolated failed login with no suspicious follow-up; a harmless configuration warning on a non-critical lab system. | Log the event, validate the alert, apply a simple correction if required, and monitor for recurrence. Close only when the rationale and evidence are recorded. |

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| | after review; a minor policy deviation corrected promptly. | | |

**Suggested response targets (internal planning only)**

Critical — immediate escalation

High — escalate as soon as practicable during the active response

Medium — investigate within the current working period

Low — review during routine monitoring. These are proposed targets, not legal or regulatory deadlines.

**Classification Rules**

- Classify by impact and evidence, not by alert label alone. An alert from a tool such as Wazuh is a lead for investigation; validate it against logs, host activity, network evidence, and the asset's importance.
- Use the highest credible severity. If the incident could affect mission-critical maritime operations, privileged accounts, or restricted data, start at the higher plausible level while facts are confirmed.
- Severity can change. Reassess when new evidence appears, when the incident spreads, when data exposure is confirmed, or when containment reduces the impact.
- Vulnerability does not automatically equal incident. An exposed or outdated service found during scanning is a vulnerability finding. Classify it as an incident when there is evidence or a credible indication of exploitation or unauthorized activity.
- Do not delay urgent containment solely to complete paperwork. Record actions and times as soon as practicable, while preserving evidence and coordinating actions that could affect operational or safety-related systems.

- Close only with a documented decision. Record what was checked, the evidence considered, why the severity was assigned, and who approved closure.

**Quick Decision Guide**

| **Question** | **If YES** | **If NO / NOT YET** |
|---|---|---|
| Is a critical operational, command, surveillance, or safety-related service compromised or disrupted? | Start at CRITICAL; escalate immediately and coordinate containment with the operational owner. | Continue assessment. |
| Is sensitive data confirmed exposed, or is a privileged account/server credibly compromised? | Use CRITICAL or HIGH depending on scope and operational impact; escalate promptly. | Continue assessment. |
| Is there credible evidence of successful unauthorized access, exploitation, or malware on an important system? | Use HIGH at minimum unless broader impact justifies CRITICAL. | Continue assessment. |
| Is this a limited suspicious event or contained low-impact issue with no evidence of compromise? | Use MEDIUM if investigation is needed; LOW only if evidence supports low impact. | Keep investigating; do not label an unresolved event harmless without a recorded basis. |

**Example Classification of Potential GMDC Events**

| Potential event | Initial classification | Reason / reassessment trigger |
|---|---|---|
| Nessus or Nmap identifies an old service version, but no exploitation evidence exists. | Vulnerability finding; not automatically an incident. | Track in the vulnerability/risk register. Reclassify as an incident if there is evidence of exploitation, unauthorized access, or active attack. |
| Wazuh flags a suspicious login to a server; investigation is ongoing. | Medium initially; raise to High/Critical if privileged access or critical impact is confirmed. | Validate account, source, time, successful/failed status, and related activity. |
| Confirmed use of a backdoor to gain root-level access on a server. | Critical if broad privilege or mission-critical systems/data are affected; otherwise at least High. | Preserve logs and volatile evidence where practical; coordinate urgent isolation and credential/key rotation. |
| A user reports a suspicious email but has not opened the attachment or entered credentials. | Low or Medium depending on spread and evidence. | Block/report the message, check whether others received it, and raise severity if execution, credential theft, or wider targeting is found. |
| Confirmed restricted data copied to an unauthorized destination. | Critical or High depending on sensitivity, scope, and operational consequences. | Escalate immediately; preserve evidence and follow the organization’s applicable privacy/legal reporting process. |

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| A single failed login with no suspicious follow-up. | Low. | Record and monitor; raise severity if repeated attempts, successful login, or account changes appear. |

**Incident Classification Record**

Complete this record for each suspected or confirmed incident and update it when severity changes. Use the Incident Response Playbook for the detailed response steps.

| **Field** | **Information to record** |
|---|---|
| Incident ID / date and time | Unique identifier; when first detected; timezone; when reported. |
| Reporter / detection source | Person, monitoring alert, system log, user report, or other source. |
| Affected asset(s) | Hostname/IP, service, account, data type, asset owner, and whether the asset is mission-critical. |
| Observed evidence | Relevant alerts/logs, source and destination, timestamps, screenshots or evidence references; avoid altering originals. |
| Initial severity and rationale | Low / Medium / High / Critical; explain the evidence and potential impact supporting the decision. |

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| Incident Lead / owner | Assigned responder and the person responsible for the affected asset. |
| Containment and communication | Actions taken, approvals/coordination, who was notified, and when. |
| Reassessment / closure | Severity changes and reasons; recovery checks; lessons learned; closure approval. |

**Approval and maintenance**

The Security Owner should review this classification table with system and data owners, approve it through the organization's governance process, and revisit it after significant incidents, material changes to GMDC systems, or scheduled policy reviews. Adjust proposed response targets to match available staffing and any applicable obligations.